on the cinematic charisma of their leader and a strong regional appeal; the Assam Gana Parishad also won its first election in 1985, but it was an extension of a six-year-long popular students' agitation.

AAP, on the other hand, did not have a film legend to lead it, no long history of agitational politics, limited funding and no strong organizational base. What it did have, though, was the infectious energy and ideas of a young, highly motivated team. And yes, it had an issue which felt urgent at the time—public anger against political corruption.

Kejriwal crafted his political strategy for Delhi brilliantly. The symbolism of the aam aadmi in a Gandhi topi with a *jhadu* (broom) in hand taking on Delhi's entrenched VIP culture was too powerful to ignore. 'I wanted the man on the street to identify with us. The Gandhi topi which we had used during the Anna movement and a jhadu gave us that identity,' he told me later.

I visited the AAP headquarters once and was struck by how young and enthusiastic everyone was. It felt to me that the spirit of idealism and voluntarism, which seemed to have disappeared from politics, had been revived here. A merchant banker who had quit his job to join the AAP told me, 'When I was making money at the bank, I didn't really know who I was making it for. Now, when I am collecting funds for AAP, I know I am involved in nation building.'

The AAP's tactics were almost guerrilla-like, a 'hit-and-run' politics designed to create a constant made-for-TV drama. I remember when Manish Sisodia, Kejriwal's man Friday and a former journalist, came to see us seeking media support for their campaign against inflated power bills. 'Arvindji will be going on a fast on the issue, please do cover it well,' he requested. I must confess a certain weariness had developed over Kejriwal's perpetual dharna politics, and the newsroom wasn't too excited.

The dharna was on a Sunday, usually a slow news day. Kejriwal had most likely chosen the day for this very reason. But he wasn't going to make this a routine news event. He asked the gathered crowds to burn their electricity bills and then climbed up an electricity pole himself. Pandemonium broke